Haji Khan Kakar was a slippery, ambitious and unscrupulous figure even by the standards of nineteenth-century Afghan power politics. His ancestors had long played the role of regional power-brokers and king-makers. Having risen in the service of Dost Mohammad, who had appointed him first governor of Bamiyan and then commander of his elite cavalry, he had already twice deserted the Amir, most recently at the Battle of Jamrud in 1837. But he always played his hand with skill. He managed to choose his moment of side-changing with perfect timing, rising in power and importance with each successive act of treachery. Maulana Hamid Kashmiri, in the *Akbarnama*, describes him as 'the outsider, the traitor, the master of betrayal' who would use charm and flattery to achieve his duplicitous ends, 'mixing poison in sugar'. Now, at this crucial juncture, on the excuse of leading a raid on the British camp, he took the opportunity to cross sides with all his followers, hoping to make his fortune from the rich and naive foreigners, and to take up Shuja's written offer of a senior place in his government. In the process, he began a haemorrhage of defections and broke the already wavering morale of Kandahar's defenders.

Unaware of the wrecked and starved state of the invading army, in the four days that followed an ever-growing number of Kandahari noblemen crossed the lines into Shuja's camp and offered their fealty to the returning King. For Shuja it was the miracle he had almost despaired of ever seeing take place. For Dost Mohammad's two Barakzai half-brothers in Kandahar, there was nothing to be done but watch the defections with growing despair:

In disarray, like maddened elephants
They were tormented by boundless rage

Those two fierce lions, all they wanted
Was to unsheathe the sword of revenge and enmity

But they lacked friends and their army was too small
After the treachery of Haji Kakar

They sat locked up behind the gates of the fort
Their hearts broken from this turn of fortune

When they saw the division in their own ranks
Particularly in the Shah's tribe of Popalzai
They did not see any other way
But to remove themselves to another country